We Believe

Leader Guide — Phrase-by-Phrase Commentary

Introduction for the Leader

The Nicene Creed was born in crisis. In 325 AD, the priest Arius of Alexandria was teaching that the Son of God was a creature — exalted, yes, but created, not truly God. The Council of Nicaea gathered 318 bishops to defend the truth. Their words became the Creed we confess every Sunday.

St. Athanasius, then a young deacon, stood at the heart of this battle. For decades he was exiled, hunted, and condemned — yet he never wavered. "Athanasius contra mundum," they said: Athanasius against the world. He is the reason we can say "of one essence with the Father" today.

> **How to use this guide:** In Teaching Mode, pause after each phrase is placed and share the commentary below. You do not need to read every note — choose what is most helpful for your group.

Article 1: God the Father (Cards 1-4)

"We believe in one God"

The very first word is "We" — not "I." The Creed is the confession of the whole Church together. And "one God" stands against all the gods of the ancient world. There is only one Creator.

"God the Father, the Pantocrator"

Pantocrator means "Almighty" or "Ruler of All." Look up at the dome in any Coptic church: Christ Pantocrator gazes down, holding everything in His hand. The Father rules not by force but by love.

"Who made heaven and earth, and all things seen and unseen"

"Unseen" includes the angels, the spiritual realm, and all that is beyond our senses. God made *everything* — there is nothing outside His creation except God Himself.

Article 2: God the Son (Cards 5-25)

"The Only-Begotten Son of God, begotten of the Father before all ages"

This is the heart of the battle with Arius. "Begotten" means the Son comes from the Father's own nature — not created from nothing. "Before all ages" means there was never a time when the Son did not exist.

"Light of Light, true God of true God"

St. Athanasius used the image of a candle lit from another candle: the same fire, not a lesser fire. The Son is not a dimmer God — He is the same God, the same Light.

"Begotten, not made; of one essence with the Father"

The Greek word is *homoousios*. This single word was the most controversial in the Creed. Arius would have accepted "similar" essence. The Council insisted on "same" essence. The difference is everything.

"Who for us men and for our salvation came down from heaven"

God did not become human because He was curious or because He had to. He did it "for us" — out of love, for our rescue. This is the staggering claim of Christianity.

"Was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and of the Virgin Mary, and became man"

The incarnation is real. God truly took human flesh from St. Mary. He did not pretend to be human. He became what we are so that we might become what He is.

"Crucified for us under Pontius Pilate"

Naming Pilate anchors this in real history. This is not myth. This happened at a specific time, under a specific Roman governor, in a real place.

"The third day He rose from the dead, according to the Scriptures"

The Resurrection is the foundation of everything. Without it, as St. Paul says, our faith is in vain. "According to the Scriptures" tells us this was always God's plan — foretold by the prophets.

Article 2 (continued)

"He ascended into the heavens and sits at the right hand of His Father"

"Sits at the right hand" means Christ shares the Father's authority and glory. He did not leave us — He reigns now, interceding for us.

"He shall come again in His glory to judge the living and the dead"

The Christian hope is not that the world will gradually improve. It is that Christ will return, visibly and gloriously, to set all things right.

Article 3: God the Holy Spirit (Cards 26-28)

"The Lord, the Giver of Life, who proceeds from the Father"

The Holy Spirit is not a force or an energy — He is Lord, a Person of the Trinity. "Proceeds from the Father" follows John 15:26 precisely. The Orthodox Church has always rejected the later Western addition "and the Son" (the filioque).

Article 4: The Church (Cards 29-30)

"One, holy, catholic, and apostolic Church"

One: There is one Church, not many. **Holy:** Set apart by God. **Catholic:** Universal — for all peoples everywhere (not "Roman Catholic"). **Apostolic:** Built on the Apostles' teaching, with an unbroken chain of ordination from the Apostles to our bishops today.

"One baptism for the remission of sins"

Baptism can only happen once because we are born again once. It is not a ceremony — it is death and resurrection with Christ.

Article 5: Final Declarations (Cards 31-32)

"The resurrection of the dead and the life of the age to come"

Christianity does not promise escape from the body but the transformation of the body. We will be raised, as Christ was raised, in glory. "The life of the age to come" is eternal life with God — the purpose for which we were made.

Closing Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, the Only-Begotten Son of God, Light of Light, true God of true God — we thank You for the faith delivered to us through the holy fathers of Nicaea and through Your servant St. Athanasius.*
>
> *Grant us courage to confess this faith without compromise, as they did. Grant us understanding to know what we believe and why. And grant us love, that our confession may come not from duty but from the overflow of grateful hearts.*
>
> *Through the intercessions of St. Athanasius, St. Cyril, and all who defended the faith — Lord, have mercy. Amen.*